

A LAND IN FLUX
Photos by Ian Lockwood and (bottom) a 1996 picture of Lockwood at work



PHOTOGRAPHY

ON HIGHER Ground





SKY ISLANDS, IAN LOCKWOOD'S EXHIBITION OF PHOTOGRAPHS OF THE WESTERN GHATS AT NCPA, MUMBAI, HIGHLIGHTS A BEAUTIFUL AND EMBATTLED LANDSCAPE

As a student of Kodaikanal International School (KIS) in the 1980s, Ian Lockwood spent his formative years in the Palani Hills, which ignited a lifelong love for the region and its ecology. Now an educator in Colombo, he has been photographing the high-altitude habitats of the Western Ghats for over three decades. This impressive body of work–mostly in black & white–will be seen at *Sky Islands: An Endangered Indian Landscape*, an exhibition that opens at NCPA, Mumbai, on November 23.

"The Sky Islands of the Western Ghats/ Sri Lanka biodiversity hotspot, sometimes called Shola Sky Islands, are areas with unique biodiversity that are separated from lower plains areas," explains Lockwood. "Relatively higher altitudes and isolation from other neighbouring ranges make them veritable 'islands' of biodiversity." This fragile landscape, vulnerable to large-scale tree planting, mining, hill-station development, agriculture and, of course, climate change, has experienced profound changes since Lockwood began photographing it in the late 1980s and early 1990s. Documenting this transformation lies at the heart of his work. It's demanding work because, while some photographs offer familiar vistas from accessible locations, others require complex permissions, days of trekking, and sheer doggedness.

Over the decades, Lockwood, like everyone else, has made the journey from analog to digital. While his early work utilised medium-format film to depict high levels of detail–and he still loves working with the "classic Hasselblad-style 6x6 medium-format camera"–he has now MacGyvered his setup and uses a Nikon DSLR to "get equally detailed images by taking multiple exposures and stitching them together". "This works for static landscapes, but is not very useful for moving objects and portraits," says Lockwood. "The exhibition has images of scanned medium-format negatives and stitched digital images that haven't been printed or shown in public before."

Among inspirations, Lockwood counts his father, Merrick, who built his own view cameras, and exposed him to the great photographers of the American West. "Iconic artists such as Ansel Adams and Edward Weston depicted landmark landscapes in black & white with both aesthetic and conservation goals. This provided a model for my approach," says Lockwood. Closer home, he cites the Bangladeshi photographer Shahidul Alam and Indian documentary photographers like Raghu Rai, Dayanita Singh, Ketaki Sheth and Sooni Taraporevala.

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Proceeds from the sale of the photographs will go towards supporting KIS's new Center for Environment & Humanity, which focuses on education, outreach and research in the Sky Islands of the Palani Hills. Lockwood last exhibited in Mumbai in 2001. "It has been a stubborn determination to keep coming back and not give up on my pursuit to share what I hope is a fresh vision of an ancient landscape," he concludes. ■

Amit Dixit

Sky Islands will run at the Dilip Piramal Photography Gallery, NCPA, Mumbai from Nov. 23 to Dec. 3